

Usability Enhancements for `std::span`

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1 Introduction

The class template `span<ElementType, Extent>` was recently added to the working draft of the C++ International Standard [N4750]. A `span` is a lightweight object providing a “view” of an underlying contiguous array, which does not own the elements it points to. It is intended as a new “vocabulary type” for contiguous ranges, replacing the use of `(pointer, length)` pairs and, in some cases, `vector<T, A>&` function parameters.

This paper identifies several opportunities to enhance the usability of `span` by improving consistency with existing container interfaces and removing potential points of confusion for users.

An implementation of `span` including the changes detailed in this paper is available at [Github].

1.1 Terminology

For the purposes of this paper, a *fixed-size span* is a `span` whose `Extent` is greater than or equal to zero. A *dynamically-sized span* is a `span` whose `Extent` is equal to `std::dynamic_extent`.

1.2 Revision History

Revision 1

- Update to reflect Rapperwil straw polls:
 - Add `front()` and `back()` member function to `span`? 3 | 7 | 5 | 1 | 0
 - Add `at()` member function? 0 | 0 | 4 | 4 | 5
 - Mark `empty()` `[[nodiscard]]`? *Unanimous consent*
 - Add non-member subview operations? 0 | 0 | 5 | 5 | 2
 - Remove `operator()`? 5 | 12 | 0 | 0 | 0
 - Add structured binding support for fixed-size `span`? *Unanimous consent*

Accordingly, the proposals to add `at()` and non-member subview operations have been removed from this revision

Revision 0

- Initial revision

2 Proposals

2.1 Add `front()` and `back()` member functions

To improve consistency with standard library containers, we propose adding `front()` and `back()` member functions with their usual meanings (that is, returning references to the first and last elements respectively). The effect of calling these functions on an empty `span` is undefined.

2.2 Mark `empty()` as `[[nodiscard]]`

The `empty()` member functions of standard library containers are decorated with the `[[nodiscard]]` attribute, to make it clearer to users that this function is an observer and does not modify the container state [P0600R1]. For consistency, this paper adds the attribute to `span::empty()` as well.

2.3 Remove `operator()`

The current wording for `span` includes an overload of the function call operator, duplicating the behaviour of `operator[]`. We assume that this is a holdover from `span`'s genesis as a multidimensional `array_view`.

Providing this operator for member access is inconsistent with other container types and with built-in language arrays. Furthermore, it provides the mistaken impression that it is possible to “invoke” a `span`. We therefore propose its removal.

2.4 Structured bindings support for fixed-size spans

Built-in arrays and `std::arrays` may be used with structured bindings, via core language and library support respectively. To allow function arguments of type `T (&)[N]` to be replaced by the more appealing `span<T, N>` with equal functionality, we propose adding support for structured bindings for fixed-size spans. Specifically, we propose a new overload of `std::get<N>()`, and specialisations of `tuple_element` and `tuple_size` for `span`.

Dynamically-sized spans cannot be decomposed. To prevent this, this proposal declares, but does not define, a partial specialization of `tuple_size` for dynamically-sized spans:

```
template <class ElementType>
struct tuple_size<span<ElementType, dynamic_extent>>; // not defined
```

Under the wording for structured bindings ([dcl.struct.bind]/3), making this specialization an incomplete type prevents the language from attempting decomposition via library types.

3 Proposed wording

Changes are relative to [N4750].

In section 26.7.2 [span.syn], add

```
// 26.7.X Tuple interface
template<class T> class tuple_size;
template<size_t I, class T> class tuple_element;

template<class ElementType, ptrdiff_t Extent>
struct tuple_size<span<ElementType, Extent>>;
template <class ElementType>
struct tuple_size<span<ElementType, dynamic_extent>>;

template<size_t I, class ElementType, ptrdiff_t Extent>
struct tuple_element<I, span<ElementType, Extent>>;
```

```
template<size_t I, class ElementType, ptrdiff_t Extent>
constexpr ElementType& get(span<ElementType, Extent>) noexcept;
```

In section 26.7.3.1 [span.overview], change

```
// 26.7.3.4, observers
constexpr index_type size() const noexcept;
constexpr index_type size_bytes() const noexcept;
[[nodiscard]] constexpr bool empty() const noexcept;

// 26.7.3.5, element access
constexpr reference operator[](index_type idx) const;
constexpr reference operator()(index_type idx) const;
constexpr reference front() const;
constexpr reference back() const;
constexpr pointer data() const noexcept;
```

In section 26.7.3.5 [span.elem], change

```
[[nodiscard]] constexpr bool empty() const noexcept;
Effects: Equivalent to: return size() == 0;

constexpr reference operator[](index_type idx) const;
constexpr reference operator()(index_type idx) const;
Requires: 0 <= idx && idx < size().
Effects: Equivalent to: return *(data() + idx);

constexpr reference front() const
Requires: empty() == false
Effects: Equivalent to return *data();

constexpr reference back() const
Requires: empty() == false
Effects: Equivalent to return *(data() + (size() - 1));
```

Add a new subsection [span.tuple]:

```
template <class ElementType, ptrdiff_t Extent>
    struct tuple_size<span<ElementType, Extent>> : integral_constant<ptrdiff_t, Extent> { };

template <class ElementType>
    struct tuple_size<span<ElementType, dynamic_extent>>; // not defined

tuple_element<I, span<ElementType, Extent>>::type
Requires: Extent != dynamic_extent && I < static_cast<size_t>(Extent). The
program is ill-formed if I is out of bounds.
Value: The type ElementType.

template <class ElementType, ptrdiff_t Extent>
    constexpr ElementType& get(span<ElementType, Extent> s) noexcept;
Requires: Extent != dynamic_extent && I < static_cast<size_t>(Extent). The
program is ill-formed if I is out of bounds.
Returns: A reference to the Ith element of s, where indexing is zero-based.
Throws: Nothing
```

References

- [Github] Tristan Brindle. Implementation of C++20 `std::span`. <https://github.com/tcbrindle/span>, 2018.
- [N4750] Richard Smith. Working Draft, Standard for Programming Language C++. <http://www.open-std.org/jtc1/sc22/wg21/docs/papers/2018/n4750.pdf>, 2018 (accessed 2018-06-24).
- [P0600R1] Nicolai Josuttis. `[[nodiscard]]` in the library, rev1. <http://www.open-std.org/jtc1/sc22/wg21/docs/papers/2017/p0600r1.pdf>, 2017.